# Feeling lonely

Most people feel lonely sometimes, for many different reasons. If loneliness is affecting your life, there are things you can try that may help.

Support is also available if you're finding it hard to cope with stress, anxiety or depression.

## Things you can try to help with loneliness

### Do

try talking about your feelings to a friend, family member, health professional or counsellor. You could also call Samaritans on 116 123 if you need someone to talk to.

consider joining a group or class that focuses on something you enjoy; you could ask to go along and just watch first if you're feeling nervous

consider visiting places where you can just be around other people – for example, a park, the cinema or a cafe

consider peer support, where people use their experiences to help each other. Find out more about peer support from Mind

get practical tips and advice to help with loneliness on Every Mind Matters

try the 6 ways to feel happier, which are simple lifestyle changes to help you feel more in control and able to cope

find out how to raise your self-esteem

listen to free mental wellbeing audio guides

### Don’t

do not try to do everything at once; set small targets that you can easily achieve

do not focus on the things you cannot change – focus your time and energy into helping yourself feel better

try not to compare yourself to others. On social media you usually only see things people want to share

try not to tell yourself that you're alone – many people feel lonely at some point in their life and support is available

try not to use alcohol, cigarettes, gambling or drugs to relieve loneliness; these can all contribute to poor mental health

Further information and support
Mind: loneliness
Mind: self-esteem
Every Mind Matters: get your free Mind Plan – get personalised mental wellbeing tips and advice to your email inbox
Where to get NHS help for stress, anxiety or depression
Referring yourself for therapy
If you need more support, you can get free talking therapies like cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) on the NHS.

You can refer yourself directly to a talking therapies service without a referral from a GP.

Find NHS talking therapies for anxiety and depression
See a GP if:
you're struggling to cope with stress, anxiety or a low mood
you've had a low mood for more than 2 weeks
things you're trying yourself are not helping
you would prefer to get a referral from a GP
Call 111 or ask for an urgent GP appointment if:
you need help urgently, but it's not an emergency
111 can tell you the right place to get help if you need to see someone. Go to NHS 111 online or call 111

Call 999 or go to A&E now if:
you or someone you know needs immediate help
you have seriously harmed yourself – for example, by taking a drug overdose
A mental health emergency should be taken as seriously as a medical emergency.

Find your nearest A&E

Do not drive to A&E. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring any medicines you take with you.

Causes of loneliness
Loneliness has many different causes and it can affect people of all ages.

It's often linked with things that could prevent you spending time with other people, such as:

living or working alone
retirement
illness or disability
bereavement (losing someone or something)

moving to a new area, job, school or university
social anxiety (social phobia)
However, you do not have to be on your own all the time to feel lonely. Many people feel lonely in a relationship or while spending time with friends or family.

Other significant life events such as buying a house, having a baby or planning a wedding could also lead to feelings of loneliness.

You might find it hard to explain to people why you feel this way, but talking to someone could help you find a solution.

Find out more about the 5 steps to mental wellbeing

Loneliness can affect people at any age, but older people are especially vulnerable to social isolation.